

videographer, Yozo Hirano. Before embarking on that trip, Maezawa said, “I’m so curious, ‘what’s life like in space?’ So, I am planning to find out on my own and share with the world...” And share he did.

But that trip was just a trial run for Maezawa’s bigger ambition. His bigger dream is to travel around the moon on an upcoming mission that he calls dearMoon, for which he has already booked all the tickets. Fashion e-commerce mogul Maezawa, who also vlogs regularly on his YouTube channel, has chosen eight other people who will accompany him on that trip aboard SpaceX’s Starship that is under development.

Maezawa isn’t alone in this luxurious pursuit. Many high-flying wealthy individuals have made the trip either to the low-earth orbit or the ISS, beginning with American businessman Dennis Tito’s journey to the space station in 2001, for which he reportedly forked out a cool \$20 million.

100 | It wasn’t always like this, of course. Space travel used to be the exclusive preserve of a select few astronauts and scientists, who were required to go through a rigorous selection and training process before they were allowed to leave the earth for scientific reasons only after Yuri Gagarin became the first human to travel to space in April 1961. Since that giant leap for mankind, more than 500 professionals have travelled to space on different scientific missions, while 12 have landed on the moon.

A similar sea change has occurred for non-professionals since Tito’s pioneering trip. In the intervening years, many self-funded non-professionals have followed in Tito’s footsteps, and that trend is only just gathering steam now with multiple companies looking to offer space tours for those wealthy enough to afford a seat on a space shuttle.

TO THE MOON AND BEYOND

With the technological advances required to make a space trip progressing rapidly, humans have maintained a continuous presence in space since the commissioning of the ISS at the turn of the millennium, and sporadically before that in other space programmes. While government-backed space programmes have progressed at a brisk pace, the entry of private operators into the business of taking people—either astronauts and scientists for a government research programme or self-funded individuals for a pleasure trip—to space has dramatically opened up the space, so to speak.

Now, private operators such as those from billionaires Elon Musk (SpaceX), Richard Branson (Virgin

The Next Frontier in Luxury Experience

1

FIRMS SUCH AS ELON MUSK’S SPACEX, RICHARD BRANSON’S VIRGIN GALACTIC AND JEFF BEZOS’S BLUE ORIGIN ARE OFFERING THE WEALTHY THE OPPORTUNITY TO GO TO SPACE

2

WHILE VIRGIN GALACTIC AND BLUE ORIGIN OFFER LOW-EARTH ORBIT (LEO) VOYAGES TO SPACE TOURISTS THAT LASTS A FEW MOMENTS, SPACEX—APART FROM OFFERING TRIPS TO LEO AND THE INTERNATIONAL SPACE STATION (ISS)—PLANS TO OFFER TRIPS AROUND THE MOON AND MARS

3

THE JOURNEY TIME TO LEO AND ISS RANGES BETWEEN A FEW HOURS AND A WEEK OR MORE, WHILE TRIPS TO THE MOON AND MARS ARE EXPECTED TO TAKE LONGER ONCE THEY START

4

NOT ONLY IS TECHNOLOGY ENABLING THESE FIRMS TO TAKE TOURISTS TO SPACE, BUT IT CAN ALSO BE CONFIGURED FOR POINT-TO-POINT TRANSPORT ON EARTH, ENABLING TRAVEL TO ANYWHERE IN THE WORLD IN AN HOUR OR LESS

5

AS MORE PRIVATE INDIVIDUALS TAKE THE PLUNGE, THE COST OF SUCH PROGRAMMES IS EXPECTED TO REDUCE IN THE COMING YEARS